

Head Coverings For Women In Worship

prc-head-coverings-for-women-in-worship
Worship Structure · Symbolism · practice · minority_lineages · brethren distinctive

DISPUTED

Supported across many Bible texts
Subject named directly in Scripture
Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

Paul's instruction in 1 Corinthians 11 about women covering their heads during prayer and prophecy in the gathered assembly continues to apply; the head-covering is a sign of the creation-order distinction Paul names there, applicable in the gathered assembly today (whether by literal covering or by another culturally-coherent sign of that distinction).

In plain language

The words for covering and uncovering the head here, 'to cover' (katakalypto) and 'uncovered' (akatakalyptos), occur nowhere else in the whole Bible. So do the words for the woman having long hair and the hair itself, and the word for hair, 'long hair' (kome), occurs only this once (a hapax, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible). Inside the chapter Paul does plainly tie a covering to women praying and prophesying. Verse 6 ends with a direct command form, let her be covered, and verse 6 also treats being shorn or shaved as a separate shameful thing from being uncovered, which suggests the covering is a cloth and not just the hair. He grounds the difference between man and woman in the creation account, and that ordering idea does appear elsewhere, in Genesis and again in another letter, so the underlying principle is not invented for one occasion. That part leans toward something lasting. But the chapter then shifts its footing. Paul appeals to nature ('nature', phusis), to long hair ('wearing long hair', komao), to honor and shame, and to the custom ('custom', synetheia) of the churches, all words that can describe either a fixed order or a local sense of what is fitting. He says the hair is given to the woman in place of a covering, and the small word 'instead of' (anti) there usually means instead of, which would make the hair itself the covering and weaken the case for a separate cloth, though it can also mean corresponding to. The word for covering in that line, 'wrap' (peribolaion), used only one other place in the Bible, means a garment there. There is also a hard line in verse 10 saying the woman should have authority ('authority', exousia) on her head, where the word for authority everywhere else means power a person actually holds, not a sign of being under someone, so even the grammar resists a single reading. So the passage points two ways at once. The command and the creation grounding read as binding in its setting, but because the covering words appear only here, the hair word is a one-time word, and the key small words carry more than one attested sense, the language cannot settle whether the specific sign binds across all times and places. It is genuinely contested, and the deciding factors lie outside what word study and concordance can supply.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0177	ἀκατακάλυπτος	akatakalyptos	uncovered	2
G0473	ἀντί	anti	for	22
G1135	γυνή	gunē	woman	

G1223	διά	dia	through/because of	
G1391	δόξα	doxa	glory	167
G1577	ἐκκλησία	ekklēsia	assembly	
G1849	ἐξουσία	exousia	authority	103
G2617	καταισχύνω	kataischyno	to dishonor	13
G2619	κατακαλύπτω	katakalypto	to cover	3
G2751	κείρω	keiro	to shear	4
G2776	κεφαλή	kephale	head	76
G2863	κομάω	komao	be long-haired	2
G2864	κόμη	kome	hair	1
G3587	ξυράω	xurao	to shave	3
G3784	ὀφείλω	opheilo	to owe	35
G4018	περιβόλαιον	peribolaion	covering	2
G4336	προσεύχομαι	proseuchomai	to pray	86
G4395	προφητεύω	propheteuo	to prophesy	28
G4914	συνήθεια	synetheia	custom	3
G5449	φύσις	phusis	nature	14

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

Inside 1 Corinthians 11 the instruction is explicit. The verb 'to cover the head' (katakalypto, G2619) and the adjective 'uncovered' (akatakalyptos, G0177) attach the covering to a woman praying or prophesying. Verse 6 ends with the command form 'let her be covered' (katakalyptestho), the man-and-woman distinction is grounded in the creation sequence in verses 7 to 9, and verse 16 appeals to the practice of the churches, all of which read straightforwardly as a binding instruction in its setting. The trans-cultural reach (whether the rule carries across times and places) is what the words leave open. The covering vocabulary, namely 'to cover' (katakalypto), 'uncovered' (akatakalyptos), 'to wear long hair' (komao), 'long hair' (kome), and 'wrap or garment' (peribolaion), occurs only in this one passage, so its sense cannot be triangulated (cross-checked) against the rest of the canon. The noun 'long hair' (kome, G2864) is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible). Verse 15 says the hair is given 'instead of a wrap' (anti peribolaion), where the preposition 'instead of' or 'in place of' (anti, G0473) carries its dominant canonical sense (its most common meaning across the Bible) instead of yet also a minor sense corresponding to, so it cannot be settled whether the hair replaces a cloth or parallels one. Because the creation-order PRINCIPLE is pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible) but the covering SIGN vocabulary is local and lexically ambiguous (open to more than one meaning at the word level), the words sustain both a continuing and a culturally conditioned reading, leaving the proposition materially contested.

Scripture

1Cor.11.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2776 κεφαλή, G2617 καταισχύνω, G4336 προσεύχομαι

Reasoning. A man praying or prophesying with something down over his head ('having down from head', kata kephales echon, a thing on the head, not the hair) shames his head. The covering in view is a removable object, set in a paired contrast with the woman, and the trigger context is praying and prophesying, which in the surrounding chapters is gathered-assembly activity.

1Cor.11.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4395 προφητεύω, G0177 ἀκατακάλυπτος, G2617 καταισχύνω

Reasoning. A woman praying or prophesying with her head 'uncovered' (akatakalyptos) shames her head, the clause running parallel to the man clause, the shame likened to being 'shaved' (exuremene). The text plainly attaches a covering distinction to the woman engaged in prayer and prophecy, supporting that a covering distinction is in view during worship. That the canon elsewhere has women prophesying (Acts 21:9, Acts 2:17) yet also has 1 Corinthians 14:34 about women keeping silent shows the words do not by themselves fix the assembly setting.

1Cor.11.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2619 κατακαλύπτω, G2751 κείρω, G3587 ξυράω

Reasoning. The verse runs an if-then chain (a conditional clause) that ends in the third person command form 'let her be covered' (katakalyptestho). Crucially it treats being 'shorn' or 'cut short' (keiro) or 'shaved' (xurao) as a SEPARATE shameful alternative to not being covered, which presses toward the covering being a cloth distinct from the hair, since otherwise the not-covered woman and the shorn woman would describe the same act rather than two. The imperative mood (command form) is the strongest single grammatical signal that an instruction is given.

1Cor.11.7 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3784 ὀφείλω, G2776 κεφαλή, G1391 δόξα

Reasoning. The man 'ought not' (opheilo, obligation language, a verb of moral duty) to cover his head because he is the image and 'glory' (doxa) of God, while the woman is the glory of man. The obligation verb and the image-and-glory grounding push toward a non-arbitrary distinction. The grounding is given as the reason for the practice, not as an explicit statement that the cloth itself binds in every culture.

1Cor.11.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1223 διά, G1135 γυνή

Reasoning. The 'woman' (gyne) was created 'for the sake of' (dia plus accusative, the noun in the direct-object grammatical form) the man, echoing the Genesis sequence. The 'for the sake of' (dia) clause anchors the man-and-woman distinction in creation rather than in a passing local fashion, and the same creation-order argument recurs at 1 Timothy 2:13, so the underlying PRINCIPLE is attested beyond this passage even though the covering sign is not.

1Cor.11.10 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1849 ἐξουσία, G2776 κεφαλή

Reasoning. The woman ought to have 'authority or power' (exousia, G1849) on her head, because of the angels. Across all 103 canonical uses 'authority' (exousia) means power or authority that one actively holds or exercises, never elsewhere a passive token of being under authority. Read by its normal sense the clause says the woman has authority on her own head, which sits oddly with the subordination logic of verses 7 to 9, so interpreters must either supply an unattested sense (a sign of authority over her) or take it at face value. This is a genuine grammatical and lexical (word-level) knot the passage does not resolve in its own words.

1Cor.11.14 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5449 φύσις, G2863 κομάω

Reasoning. Paul appeals to 'nature or inborn order' (phusis, G5449) and asks whether nature teaches that 'wearing long hair' (komao) on a man is a dishonor. Across the canon 'nature' (phusis) can mean fixed created order (Romans 1:26, Romans 2:14) or ingrained disposition and custom, and the vocabulary here does not state which sense governs, so grounding the argument in 'nature' (phusis) and in honor and shame is the lexical signal most often read as time-and-place conditioned, which complicates a strictly perpetual reading.

1Cor.11.15 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0473 αντί, G2864 κόμη, G4018 περιβόλαιον

Reasoning. The 'long hair' (kome, a hapax, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) is given to the woman 'instead of a wrap' (anti peribolaion). The preposition 'instead of' (anti, G0473) in its dominant canonical sense means instead of or in exchange for ('eye for eye' Matthew 5:38, 'ransom for many' Mark 10:45, 'evil for evil' Romans 12:17), with only a minor 'corresponding-to' sense, and 'wrap or garment' (peribolaion, G4018) in its one other canonical use, Hebrews 1:12, plainly means a garment or wrap likened to a cloak. If 'instead of' (anti) means instead of, the chapter supplies its own covering through the hair and weakens the case for a separate cloth. If it means corresponding to, the hair merely parallels a cloth the woman should also wear. Morphology (word form analysis) alone cannot decide, and this is the central lexical (word-level) ambiguity of the passage.

1Cor.11.16 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4914 συνήθεια, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Reasoning. Paul closes by appealing to 'custom or settled habit' (synetheia, G4914) and the practice of the 'churches or assemblies' (ekklesia, depending on whether the word marks the gathered assembly or the church as institution), saying neither we nor the churches of God have such a custom. 'Custom' (synetheia) occurs only three times in the canon (here, 1 Corinthians 8:7 of an ingrained habit of conscience, John 18:39 of a local Passover custom), so its attested range covers both ingrained habit and settled communal usage. Closing on custom and corporate practice rather than on a bare standalone command is read by some as anchoring the matter in shared apostolic usage that continues and by others as locating it in adjustable church custom, which keeps the permanence question open.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
1Cor.11.7	Gen.2.18	openbible	31
1Cor.11.7	Gen.1.26	openbible	22
1Cor.11.7	Gen.1.27	openbible	21
1Cor.11.3	Gen.3.16	openbible	19
1Cor.11.3	Eph.5.23	openbible	14
1Cor.11.3	1Cor.14.34	openbible	11
1Cor.11.8	Gen.2.22	openbible	18
1Cor.11.8	1Tim.2.13	openbible	12
1Cor.11.5	1Cor.14.34	openbible	13
1Cor.11.5	Gen.24.65	openbible	3
1Cor.11.10	Gen.24.65	openbible	2
1Cor.11.6	Num.5.18	tsk	1
1Cor.11.5	Deut.21.12	tsk	1

Complicating texts

1Cor.11.15 · addressed

The phrase 'instead of a wrap' (anti peribolaion) turns on the preposition 'instead of' (anti, G0473) and the noun 'wrap or garment' (peribolaion, G4018). Across the canon 'instead of' (anti) most often means instead of or in exchange for, but it also carries a corresponding-to sense in a minority of constructions, and 'wrap' (peribolaion) in its only other occurrence (Hebrews 1:12) clearly denotes a garment. Morphology (word form analysis) alone cannot decide which sense of 'instead of' (anti) governs here, so the verse legitimately supports both a hair-is-the-covering reading and a hair-corresponds-to-the-covering reading. The hapax (only-once-in-the-Bible) status of 'long hair' (kome, G2864) removes any second context for triangulating (cross-checking) the image. This irreducible ambiguity is recorded as a driver of the disputed verdict rather than resolved against the text.

1Cor.11.14 · addressed

The appeal to 'nature' (phusis, G5449) and to honor and shame categories is a principal complicating signal for permanence. 'Nature' (phusis) is attested across the canon for both fixed created order and ingrained custom, and the vocabulary does not state which is meant here, so it neither secures nor refutes perpetual application. It is retained as a genuine tension feeding the disputed verdict.

1Cor.11.16 · addressed

The closing appeal to 'custom or settled habit' (synetheia, G4914) and to the practice of the churches can be read either as grounding the matter in shared apostolic usage that continues or as locating it in adjustable church custom. The three canonical uses of 'custom' (synetheia) span ingrained habit and communal usage, so the lexical (word-level) data alone does not adjudicate between these readings, and the verse is logged as unresolved tension contributing to the disputed verdict.

1Cor.11.10 · unaddressed

The clause that the woman ought to have 'authority or power' (exousia, G1849) on her head because of the angels is not resolved by the lexical (word-level) data. 'Authority' (exousia) in all other canonical uses means actively held power, not a passive symbol of submission, so the natural sense (the woman has authority on her head) clashes with the subordination grounding of verses 7 to 9, and the meaning of because of the angels has no concordance support to fix it. No reading is foreclosed and none is secured by the words, so this is left as an open lexical and grammatical knot rather than resolved.

Concordance traversed

G2619, G0177, G2863, G2864, G4018, G0473, G2776, G1849, G4914, G5449, G2617, G3784, G4395, G4336, G2751, G3587, G1391

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units were supplied in the bundle for 1 Corinthians 11, and 1 Corinthians is outside the published ECM (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) 3 John sample, so any apparatus reading here is shadow status. The editorial marks in the supplied text at verses 2, 3, 5, 7, 10, 11, 14, 15 touch word order and minor pronoun and article readings that do not move the verdict, since the contested terms 'to cover' (katakalupto), 'uncovered' (akatakalyptos), 'instead of' (anti), 'wrap' (peribolaion), 'long hair' (kome), and 'authority' (exousia) are textually stable in the supplied text.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. creation_order, cultural_accommodation, new_covenant_practice

analogia scripturae invoked

creation_order: leans for · Verses 7 to 9 ground the sex distinction in the Genesis creation sequence through the 'for the sake of' (dia) clause and the image-and-glory language. The cross-reference net to Genesis 1:26, Genesis 1:27, Genesis 2:18, and Genesis 2:22 is dense and high-vote, and the same Genesis-order argument recurs at 1 Timothy 2:13, so the man-and-woman ordering PRINCIPLE reads as a trans-temporal (cross-time) basis. On this lens the sign attaches to that lasting order and the proposition leans toward continuing application, including a culturally coherent equivalent of the sign.

cultural_accommodation: leans against · Verses 13 to 16 ground the argument in 'nature' (phusis), in long hair as 'wearing long hair' (komao) and 'long hair' (kome), in honor and shame, and in the 'custom' (synetheia) of the churches, all vocabulary whose attested range includes time-and-place conditioned propriety. Read this way the specific cloth covering is a culturally coded sign of the underlying distinction, so the external form need not bind today even if the distinction it signified does. The dominant instead-of sense of 'instead of' (anti) in verse 15 reinforces this lens by letting the hair itself stand as the God-given covering.

new_covenant_practice: insufficient · The covering vocabulary, namely 'to cover' (katakalupto), 'uncovered' (akatakaluptos), 'wearing long hair' (komao), 'long hair' (kome), and 'wrap or garment' (peribolaion), does not recur anywhere else in the New Testament. 'Long hair' (kome) is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), and 'wrap' (peribolaion) appears only once more in a non-covering context. There is no second corporate-practice text using these words against which to test whether the apostolic churches treated the covering as a perpetual ordinance or a local arrangement, so the permanence of the specific sign is lexically (at the word level) underdetermined.

The 'comparing Scripture with Scripture' (analogia scripturae) check cuts two ways and is the heart of the dispute. The man-and-woman ordering PRINCIPLE is genuinely pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible: Genesis 1 to Genesis 3, 1 Timothy 2:13, Ephesians 5:23, Colossians 3:18, 1 Peter 3:1), so comparing Scripture with Scripture supports the distinction Paul names. But the covering SIGN vocabulary is confined to this one passage, so the same principle supplies almost no independent material for the external sign itself. The verdict therefore separates a well-attested principle from a locally-attested and lexically ambiguous (open to more than one word-level meaning) sign.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Examine whether the head-covering instruction in 1 Corinthians 11 about women praying and prophesying is presented as binding on the gathered assembly beyond the original setting, and on what basis (creation order, nature, or church custom) the text grounds the sign.

The proposition embeds its conclusion in two ways. First, it asserts that the instruction continues to apply, which is the contested question rather than a given. Second, it pre-interprets the sign as one of the creation-order distinction Paul names and then broadens it to whether by literal covering or by another culturally-coherent sign, which already concedes a substitution the text does not explicitly authorize. The verdict was derived on the original stem, and the neutralized form strips the continues-to-apply and culturally-coherent-substitute framing so the lexical (word-level) data can speak. The verdict remains disputed, unchanged from the prior file, now supported by additional queried data (the distributions of 'authority' (exousia) and 'wrap' (peribolaion), the 'long hair' (kome) hapax (only-once-in-the-Bible), the dominant instead-of sense of 'instead of' (anti), and the pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible) reach of the creation-order principle versus the local reach of the covering vocabulary).

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2619
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0177
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1849
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4018
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0473

morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.11.6
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Cor.11.15
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	1Cor.11.7
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Cor.11.5

License audit

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Source	License	Redistribute
STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes
OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes
TSK	public_domain	yes

Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow · complicating-unresolved